

Passages - the Outsider

I thought that it was one more Sunday nearly over and done with, that Mama was now dead and buried, that I would go back to work, and that when all was said and done, nothing had really changed.

Then he asked me whether I would be interested in changing my life. I replied that you can never really change your life and that, in any case, every life was more or less the same and that my life here wasn't bad at all. He looked displeased, told me I could never give a straight answer, that I had no ambition and that this was disastrous in business. So I went back to work. I would have preferred not to upset him, but I could see no reason to change my life. After giving it serious thought, I wasn't unhappy. When I was a student, I was very ambitious about having a career. But when I had to give up my studies, I realized quite soon that none of that sort of thing mattered very much.

His life had changed now and he didn't quite know what he was going to do.

It was then that everything started to sway. The sea heaved a heavy, scorching sigh. The sky seemed to split apart from end to end to pour its fire down upon me.

He asked one last time if I believed in God. I said no. He sat down looking indignant. He said that was impossible, that everyone believed in God, even those who turned away from Him. This was his firm belief, and if he ever had cause to doubt it, his life would no longer have any meaning. Do you want my life to have no meaning? he shouted. In my opinion, that was none of

my business and I told him so.

But from across the table, he was already thrusting the Christ figure in my face and screaming like a madman: I am a Christian! I ask Christ to forgive your sins! How can you not believe that He suffered for you?' It struck me that he was now addressing me in a very personal way, as if I were a child, but I'd had enough. It was getting hotter and hotter. As always, whenever I want to get rid of people I'm barely listening to, I try to look as if I'm agreeing with them.

All the interminable hours and days when they had talked about my soul, I had the impression that everything was merging to form a colourless pool of swirling water that was spinning all around me.

she had perhaps grown tired of being the mistress of a man condemned to death. It also occurred to me that she might be sick or dead. Such things happen; it was natural. There was no way of knowing because apart from our two bodies, now separated, nothing bound us to each other, nothing kept us alive to each other.

Although, if I discovered that was the case, I would become indifferent to the memory of Marie. She would no longer interest me once she was dead.

I found that idea normal, just as I completely understood why people would forget me after I died. They would no longer have anything to do with me. I couldn't even say that such an idea was difficult to accept.

I don't know why, something burst inside me. I started shouting at the top of my lungs and swore at him and told him not to pray for me. I grabbed him by the collar of his cassock. I poured out all the feelings

that surged up from the depths of my heart in waves of anger and joy. He seemed so sure of himself, didn't he? But not one of his certainties was worth a single strand of a woman's hair. He wasn't even sure he was alive because he lived life as if he were dead. I may look as if I had nothing but I was sure of myself, sure of everything, sure of my life, sure of my impending death. Yes, that was all I had. But at least I had a hold on that truth as much as it had a hold on me. I'd been right, I was still right, I had always been right. I had lived my life a certain way when I could have lived it another way. I had done one thing when I might have done something else. What difference did it make? I felt as if I had been waiting all this time for this very moment and this early dawn when I would be vindicated. Nothing, nothing mattered and I knew very well why. He also knew why. From the depths of my future, throughout all this absurd life I had lived, a gathering wind swept towards me, stripping bare along its path everything that had been possible in the years gone by, years that seemed just as unreal as the ones that lay ahead. Why should the death of other people or a mother's love matter so much? Why should I care about his god, the lives, the destinies we choose when one unique destiny had chosen me, and along with me millions and millions of privileged others who, like him, called themselves my brothers? Couldn't he understand, could he really not understand? Everyone was privileged. There was no one who wasn't privileged.